

The Fire and the Wounds – Seeing the One God

Key Verse: “Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God is one LORD.” (Deuteronomy 6:4, KJV)

Beloved, the doctrine of One God is not a dull debate for scholars. It is the very oxygen of faith. Without it, our prayers scatter, our worship confuses, and our salvation crumbles. Today, we look at two men who lived on the edge of impossibility – one who called down fire from heaven, and one who touched the wounds of the risen Lord. Both succeeded not because they were braver than us, but because they grasped a single, earth-shaking truth: the God who saves is the *same* God who created, and He did not send a substitute—He came Himself.

Elijah: The Prophet Who Stood Alone

Let us go first to Mount Carmel. The nation of Israel is limping between two opinions. Four hundred and fifty prophets of Baal eat at Jezebel's table, and the people have forgotten the Shema. Elijah confronts them with a brutal challenge: “*How long halt ye between two opinions? if the LORD be God, follow him: but if Baal, then follow him*” (1 Kings 18:21). Notice Elijah does not say, “The LORD is one of many.” He demands an absolute choice because truth is singular.

The prophets of Baal cry, leap, and cut themselves from morning till noon. Silence. Then Elijah steps forward. He rebuilds the altar with twelve stones—one for each tribe—to show that the One God is the God of *all* Israel, not a tribal deity. He drenches the sacrifice with water, making victory humanly impossible. Then he prays a short, piercing prayer: “*LORD God of Abraham, Isaac, and of Israel, let it be known this day that thou art God in Israel... that I have done all these things at thy word*” (1 Kings 18:36-37). He does not pray to a committee. He prays to the *One* whose word is final. Fire falls. The people fall on their faces and cry, “*The LORD, he is the God*” (1 Kings 18:39). Elijah wins the greatest public victory in Israel's history. Why? Because he trusted that the Creator of fire is the same One who gave the Law—undivided, all-powerful, and jealous for His name.

But now we must pause and grasp a deeper truth. On Carmel, the fire declared that God is one. Yet that fire did not *make* Him one—it only *revealed* what He had always been. From everlasting to everlasting, before a single angel was made or a single human breathed, the Lord existed as the sole, solitary, self-sufficient I AM. His being as one does not depend on

miracles, crowds, or witnesses. When the fire blazed and the people shouted, He was one. But when the smoke cleared and the people wandered away, He remained just as one. The truth that God is one stands utterly independent of any earthly element—whether noise or silence, victory or defeat, a mountain packed with spectators or a cave with a single, trembling prophet. The fire on Carmel did not add to His nature, nor did the silence of Horeb subtract from it. He is not one because we believe it; He is one because He is. Our worship does not create His unity; His unity creates our worship. This is the rock we must stand on: God's being as one is eternal, unchangeable, and untouched by human circumstances. It is rooted in His own infinite self, not in our perception, not in our emotions, and not in our spiritual highs or lows.

And here is the twist that proves this point. The very next chapter, Elijah hears that Jezebel wants his head. This giant of faith, who stood fearless before 450 false prophets, now runs into the wilderness and begs to die. What happened? Did his theology fail? No. He forgot his own lesson. He looked at a woman instead of the One God. He thought the power of God was limited to dramatic shows, but he forgot that the *same* One Lord who sent fire also controls the heart of a queen. God does not scold him. Instead, He sends an angel, feeds him, and then reveals Himself—not in the wind, not in the earthquake, not in the fire, but in a “*still small voice*” (1 Kings 19:11-12). That quiet whisper is the same voice of the Father. It is not a different person; it is the same God speaking in gentleness. Elijah's success was restored when he remembered that the One who thunders on Carmel also whispers in the cave. There is no division in God—only perfect, singular love that adapts to our need, but never changes in His essential oneness. Whether the world is watching or no one is around, He is still the sole Lord of heaven and earth.

Elijah was restored through the shema. That unchanging, undivided God speaks a fresh commission: “Go, return on thy way to the wilderness of Damascus: and when thou comest, anoint Hazael to be king over Syria, and Jehu the son of Nimshi shalt thou anoint to be king over Israel, and Elisha... shalt thou anoint to be prophet in thy room” (1 Kings 19:15-16). His prophethood is restored—not because he earned it, but because the One God's purpose cannot be broken by a prophet's mood. His depression is cured—not by therapy, but by the realization that the same Lord who burned the sacrifice also numbers the hairs of his head, and that Lord has not changed from Carmel to Horeb. His fearlessness returns—not because Jezebel died, but because the One God reigns over her heart as easily as He reigns over fire.

Elijah rises, eats, and walks forty days to meet his God again. He never cowers again. The One God had restored him completely.

Thomas: The Disciple Who Demanded Proof

Now we leap to the New Testament, to a man we often call "Doubting Thomas." After the resurrection, the other disciples tell Thomas, "*We have seen the Lord.*" But Thomas replies, "*Except I shall see in his hands the print of the nails, and put my finger into the print of the nails, and thrust my hand into his side, I will not believe*" (John 20:25). Many call this unbelief. But I call it raw honesty. Thomas knew the Shema. He knew God is one, and no dead man could be God. How could the crucified Jesus be the *I AM* of Moses?

Eight days later, Jesus appears. The doors are shut, but He stands among them. He does not rebuke Thomas. He invites him: "*Reach hither thy finger, and behold my hands; and reach hither thy hand, and thrust it into my side: and be not faithless, but believing*" (John 20:27). And then comes the greatest confession in all the New Testament. Thomas does not say, "You are a mighty prophet." He does not say, "You are a second person of a trinity." He cries out, "*My Lord and my God*" (John 20:28). Think about what Thomas just said. He is a strict monotheist. If Jesus were a separate being, Thomas would have committed blasphemy. But Jesus accepts the worship and pronounces a blessing on all who believe without seeing. Why? Because Thomas finally understood the indispensable truth: the God who made the heavens had wrapped Himself in wounded flesh. The Father had not sent an angel or a junior partner to die. He had come *Himself*. Isaiah had prophesied it: "*For unto us a child is born... and his name shall be called... The mighty God, The everlasting Father*" (Isaiah 9:6). The child is called the *Everlasting Father*. Thomas looked into the face of the risen Jesus and saw the very face of Yahweh.

Why This Truth Is Indispensable for Salvation

Here is the stunning twist that ties both men together. Elijah called down fire to prove that Yahweh is the *only* God. Thomas touched the wounds to prove that the *only* God had bled. Why is this vital? Because salvation hangs on it. The Law demands a perfect, infinite sacrifice for sin. Only the Creator Himself can pay for the sins of His creation. If Jesus were a created being, His death would be finite—powerful for one, but not for billions. But Paul declares, "*God was in Christ, reconciling the world unto himself*" (2 Corinthians 5:19). And

again, *“Feed the church of God, which he hath purchased with his own blood”* (Acts 20:28). Whose blood? God's own blood. The Father did not send someone else to die—He came in flesh, took the nails, and purchased us with His own life.

Elijah succeeded because he trusted the One God to answer by fire—whether the fire roared or the voice whispered, his trust rested on the same unchanging Lord. Thomas succeeded because he recognized the One God in the scars—not in glory only, but in suffering. Both saw the same Lord—Elijah from a distance, Thomas up close. But neither saw a divided godhead. They saw the Father who is mighty to save and gentle enough to whisper, and who, in the fullness of time, became flesh so that we could see Him, touch Him, and be saved.

Beloved, when you pray, do not wonder which "person" is listening. The One who created you is the One who gave his flesh and blood for you. The same undivided heart that thundered on Sinai bled on Calvary. That is your rock. Hold it fast. It will make you stand when the world falls, and it will make you believe when all else is dark. To the One God, our Father and our Savior, be glory forever and ever.